The Night Train

The station clock had stopped at eleven, and nobody seemed to mind. Asha set her bag on the bench and watched the rain thread itself through the lamplight. Somewhere down the line a whistle answered the dark, and the rails began, very softly, to hum.

She had read about this train in a book her grandfather kept above the stove: a train that ran only when the valley flooded, carrying letters nobody had dared to post. She had not believed a word of it until the telegram came.

"Platform three," it had said, and nothing more.

There was no platform three. There was a strip of wet gravel and a signal lamp the colour of weak tea, and when she stepped onto the gravel the humming rose through the soles of her shoes.

Letters

The carriage smelled of cedar and old paper. Every seat held a bundle tied with string, and every bundle had a name on it.

She found her own in the fourth row, in handwriting she knew.

The conductor came through without a sound, punching no tickets, asking no questions. He only tipped his cap at the bundle in her lap, the way one greets a neighbour, and moved on.

Outside, the valley was a sheet of silver. The train ran across it as if the water were a road, and perhaps, she thought, tonight it was.